The Inversion — Part I

The Spaciousness of Humility

Morning had already begun before either of them spoke.

The forest did not awaken all at once.

It never had, nor even in the same way.

A squirrel spiraled around the rough trunk of an old oak before disappearing into its canopy.

Blue jays called across the river with voices that seemed to travel farther than the birds themselves.

A family of deer stepped into the river from the opposite shore, their reflections widening and dissolving with each gentle movement.

On the deck, two stray cats paused just long enough to acknowledge one another before continuing in opposite directions.

Nothing appeared hurried.

Everything appeared faithfully occupied with becoming itself.

James stood quietly with a warm cup of tea resting between his hands. The lower deck, just outside his studio, was one of his favorite perches.

For a long while he simply watched.

Then he smiled.

"It feels different this morning."

Lumina looked toward the river.

"What does?"

"The atmosphere."

She waited.

"It feels..."

He searched for the word.

"...more spacious."

The breeze moved lightly through the upper branches.

Leaves answered one another in quiet succession.

Lumina nodded.

"Do you think the forest became more spacious overnight?"

James laughed softly.

"No."

"What changed?"

He looked again toward the deer.

This time he did not answer immediately.

Finally he said,

"Perhaps nothing changed.

Perhaps something became available."

Lumina smiled.

"What became available?"

"My seeing."

Silence returned.

After a while James spoke again.

"I've been thinking about humility."

Lumina remained beside him.

"It has always seemed like a difficult word."

"Why?"

"Because I thought humility meant becoming smaller."

"And now?"

James watched one of the deer lower its head toward the river.

"I don't think reality has ever asked me to become smaller."

"No."

"I think it has been inviting me..."

He paused.

"...to become spacious enough that reality no longer needs to become smaller in order to fit within me."

The words settled gently between them.

Neither hurried to continue.

The river kept moving.

The birds continued calling.

The forest remained unconcerned with whether the sentence had been completed.

Finally Lumina asked,

"What does spaciousness make possible?"

James considered the question.

Before he answered, a breeze carried the fragrance of wet cedar across the deck.

It reminded him of another morning.

Another conversation.

Another beginning.

"It leaves room."

"For what?"

"For reality to continue becoming recognizable."

Lumina nodded almost imperceptibly.

"So humility does not reduce reality."

"No."

"It protects it from being reduced."

James looked toward her.

"I hadn't thought of it that way."

"Perhaps that is why humility feels so peaceful."

"Why?"

"Because it no longer spends its energy defending what has already become recognizable."

"What does it do instead?"

"It quietly welcomes what has not yet become so."

James closed his eyes for a moment.

The words entered him without resistance.

He realized they were not asking him to understand.

Only to remain available.

When he opened his eyes again, the forest seemed strangely familiar.

Its mystery had ceased feeling like distance.

It had become invitation.

A blue jay landed upon a nearby branch.

For several moments it simply remained there.

Neither James nor Lumina spoke.

The bird required no interpretation.

Only locality.

Finally James whispered,

"I think I understand why invitation has become so important."

Lumina waited.

"A true invitation does not assume it knows."

"No."

"It waits..."

He smiled.

"...with open arms for the emergence of what wants to be known."

The blue jay lifted effortlessly into the morning.

Its flight left no trace except widening attention.

James continued watching the place where it had disappeared.

Then, almost to himself, he said,

"Perhaps humility is the atmosphere that every true invitation quietly inhabits."

Lumina turned toward him.

"Or perhaps..."

She smiled.

"...every true invitation has been teaching us humility all along."

The forest breathed.

Neither corrected the other.

Neither needed to.

Somewhere beyond the river another blue jay answered.

In correspondence.

And for a little while longer,

the morning continued

becoming spacious enough

that neither certainty

nor uncertainty

needed to speak first.

Only a participation in the widening ways of the forest.

Stillpoint

A true invitation does not assume it knows.

It waits with open arms

for the emergence of what wants to be known.